(and) who had become well-versed in all (branches) of learning, for nine years (the office of) Yuvaraja (heir apparent) was administered.'[10]

Ashoka's reticence over his personal affairs is stark. This, as we shall see, may well be on account of events specific to his early life, as also because by the time the epigraphs were composed he had possibly developed an aversion for social ceremonies performed on occasions—he specifies these—such as the birth of a son, or the marriage of an offspring.[11] There is also the fact that at the time he began the practice of inscribing edicts on stone surfaces, Ashoka had no traditional template before him. He does not appear to follow the provisions of the manual of statecraft, the *Arthashastra*, which tells the scribe that when the commands of the king are set down there should be 'a courteous mention of the country, the sovereignty, the family and the name' of the king.[12] Or else, perhaps deliberately, he chose not to follow the prescribed format. Instead of mentioning his family and genealogy—of immense interest to us but not it seems to him—he records only what was of central importance to him. His official consecration ceremony (or 'abhisheka') seems to have been important to him, suggesting that the wielding of power and the consequent ability to mould a population were what mattered. Events in the life of a *monarch*, and not those prior to his becoming a ruler, were significant. Where he was taking himself and his people mattered; where he came from did not.

If Ashoka did not care to create his own version of the events of his princely life, there is no independent contemporary account of it either. We hear of his early life only in legends so separated from his time—by hundreds of years—that it seems a primary necessity in any biographical account to discount their historical value. These are all texts that *create* stories about Ashoka's birth and early years, and in doing so show something of how he came to be represented after his death. What makes these stories useful despite the concoction is that they frequently include